

The Boston Globe

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TUESDAY, DECEMBER 31, 2024

Critical of care at a Worcester hospital

Nurses link 2 deaths at St. Vincent ICU to unsafe staff levels

By Jonathan Saltzman
GLOBE STAFF
and Stella Tannenbaum
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Nurses at St. Vincent Hospital in Worcester allege that cost-saving measures are causing pervasive lapses in care, including two patients dying after failing to receive potentially life-saving dialysis.

The new assertions come nearly three years after nurses there settled the longest nursing strike in state history with the hospital's for-profit owner, Tenet

Healthcare, a battle waged in part over staffing levels. Now, they say, the situation has grown even more dangerous, with stretched-thin nurses often struggling to do their jobs right. The Massachusetts Nurses Association, the union that represents about 600 nurses at the hospital, alleged more than 70 concerning incidents between April and November, from preventable bedsores to unsafe rationing of limited supplies, in an 18-page complaint filed in December with federal and state officials and shared exclusively with the Globe.

Perhaps the most incendiary allegation is that two female patients in the intensive care unit on Sept. 29 died because there weren't enough nurses to provide

ST. VINCENT, Page A8



SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

Nurse Carla LeBlanc said stretched-thin nurses at St. Vincent Hospital often struggle to do their jobs right.

Health legislation delivered to Healey

Lawmakers' late scramble focused on drug costs, medical centers oversight

By Samantha J. Gross and Anjali Huynh
GLOBE STAFF

Lawmakers sent a pair of health care bills to Governor Maura Healey's desk Monday, delivering their response to some of the biggest problems facing Massachusetts residents this year — the Steward Health Care crisis and increasingly out-of-reach prescription drug costs — less than 48 hours before the two-year legislative session is set to end at midnight Wednesday.

One bill, aimed at enhancing the hospital oversight process, seeks to avoid another hospital system collapse as the state witnessed with Steward by increasing the financial reporting requirements and penalties for hospitals and their investors. The other bill, dealing with pharmaceutical access and transparency, would overhaul cost and insurance coverage requirements for certain drugs. The package would also ramp up regulations overseeing the pharmacy brokers that help set drug costs.

But with final votes taking place mere hours before the Legislature starts over in the new year, the late scramble provided another example of state lawmakers struggling to reach consensus on significant policy matters, a challenge that has increasingly plagued one of the least-transparent legislative bodies in the country in recent years. Both health care bills had stalled for months behind

BILLS, Page A12

Carter often antagonized his successors

His freelance diplomacy, sharp tongue raised tension

By Peter Baker
NEW YORK TIMES

When President Biden stopped by former president Jimmy Carter's home in Plains, Ga., in April 2021, it was more than just a show of respect from one commander in chief to another. It was the first time in the 40 years since Carter left the White House that any of his seven successors had visited him in his hometown.

Carter had a hot-and-cold relationship with the fellow members of the exclusive club of presidents — more cold than hot, in fact. From his reelection defeat in 1980 until his death Sunday, he was the odd man out, distant from the Republicans and Democrats who followed him and often getting on their nerves because of his outspokenness.

He did not join his fellow presidents on the high-dollar speaking circuit, nor did he team up for many joint humanitarian missions. He was rarely consult-

CARTER, Page A7

4 ACRES, 323 YEARS, 1 DIVISIVE DEBATE

Milton still struggles to commit to use poor farm for affordable homes

By Andrew Brinker
GLOBE STAFF

MILTON — Tucked away in a stretch of woods near this town's southern border, a tree-lined subdivision overlooks the sprawling Blue Hills Reservation. This cul-de-sac includes 23 impressive homes with garages, driveways, and yards — a patch of pleasant suburbia barely beyond the core of Boston.

It's only at the rear of this idyllic property, behind a stand of trees, that there is any

remnant of what this land once was. A few decaying buildings with boarded-up windows are all that remains of Milton's town farm, which was once a refuge for the homeless.

A decade ago, Milton's town leaders sold most of the farm land to a luxury developer, who built the collection of single-family homes that are there today. Some have called that decision "the biggest misstep the town has ever made."

Now this historic land is at the center of another bruising fight over housing in this suburb south of Boston, where the town Select Board — reshaped in the fallout of last winter's clash over a state-mandated housing plan — has hit the brakes on plans to put 35 affordable apartments on the farm's final 4 undeveloped acres.

The move has outraged local housing advocates, especially given the bequest of the

MILTON, Page A12



CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF

Julie Creamer, a housing advocate, and Tom Callahan of the Milton Affordable Housing Trust toured the historic poor farm, including the main almshouse (right), near Blue Hills Reservation. For decades, the site was a refuge for those with no homes.



Wring out the old

New Year's Eve: Rain late. High 47-52, low 40-45.

New Year's Day: Cloudy. High 47-52, low 34-39.

Sunrise: 7:13. Sunset: 4:22.

Weather and comics, D5-6.

Obituaries, C11.

VOL. 306, NO. 184

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Suggested retail price
\$4.00



Donald Trump endorsed House Speaker Mike Johnson for another term, yet his fate remained uncertain as the opening of the session neared. A2.

N.H. lawmakers drafted bills targeting some cases in which a person helps a minor receive abortion care. B1.

A look at the reasons health insurance costs in Massachusetts are among the highest in the United States. D1.

From Mass. mill town to pinnacle of power

Economic adviser to Trump found tough lessons in Greenfield's woes

By Jim Puzzanghera
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — The path Kevin Hassett took as an economist — one that will lead him to the White House again next year as a top adviser to President-elect Donald Trump — was shaped by growing up in the small Western Massachusetts community of Greenfield.

"For the longest time, Greenfield was a thriving mill town," Hassett, now 62, told senators at the 2017 confirmation hearing for his job as chair of the Council of Economic Advisers in the first Trump administration. "But as we got older, times were changing. Plants closed. Families started moving away. Graduates stopped coming home after college."

When Hassett began studying economics in college, he said, he kept coming back to the "painful transition" that took place in his hometown of about 18,000 residents and what "policy makers can do to restore prosperity."

HASSETT, Page A6



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

FESTIVITIES TAKING SHAPE — Don Chapelle (left) and Jeff Hayward carved an ice sculpture depicting a Kemp's Ridley sea turtle. The piece will be part of the annual ice sculpture stroll on New Year's Eve. B1.